the *Rig-Veda* (*R-V*), as one of the *Saptarishi*s, seven sages with quasi-divine powers, and credited as the composer of twenty-seven of the hymns in the first and earliest of the *R-V*'s ten books. He has been fathered by two early Vedic gods, Mitra and Varuna, who after being sexually aroused by the sight of a celestial nymph deposit their seed in a clay pitcher. This is found floating in the River Ganges by a rishi who names the boy born out of the pot *kumbhasambhava*, or 'jar-born'. So Agastya has very solid Vedic credentials.

Agastya's next major appearance is in the *Mahabharata*, where we learn that the Dakshina is filled with demons and, in particular, cruel snake-like creatures called Kaleyas or Kalakeyas, who hate the gods. They are destroying the Brahmins by night, leaving the earth so filled with their corpses, 'like piled-up conch shells', that very few Brahmins are left alive to study and make sacrifices to the gods. Whenever the Kshatriyas fight back to help save the Brahmins the demons hide in the oceans. So the gods call in the sage Agastya to help. But to get to the Kaleyas Agastya has first to cross the Vindhya mountain range, which in its pride has grown so high as to block the rounds of the sun and the moon. Agastya orders the Vindhyas to bow down low enough to allow him and his wife Lopamudra to cross, and to remain bowed until he returns – which he never does, so leaving the Vindhya prostrate and humbled. By this means Agastya opens a route into the Dakshina. He then drinks up the southern ocean, so enabling the gods to destroy the exposed demons, who have nowhere left to hide. He then makes his home in a series of ashrams, each one set that bit further south. Crucially, he brings with him to the Dakshina a great gift: the sacred language of Sanskrit.

So here is Agastya as the very personification of the Arya, Vedic, Brahmin and Sanskrit penetration of the Dravidian South. And he is also a devotee of Lord Vishnu – a Vaishnava.